

HOW ASSAM CLEANED THE LAND RECORDS

Inspired by PM Narendra Modi's motto of transparent governance, Assam's Mission Basundhara has streamlined land revenue services, facilitating easy access to land-related work, reducing the pendency in update of land records, and eliminating middle men. A record 8,13,981 applications were settled in seven months.

■ BY A SPECIAL CORRESPONDENT ■

"Leadership is service, not position."

This statement by American author Tim Fargo perhaps best defines the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi in India's social, political, and economic sphere. The primary principle of the Modi-led government at the Centre has been to facilitate and deliver service to the country's common citizens who have long been made to struggle—often by the administrative structure—for what are their very basic rights.

The biggest achievement of Prime Minister Modi has been that he has not only made hassle-free deliverance of service the motto of the Central government but also inspired many other political leaders to walk the same path. One such leader is Assam's Chief Minister Dr Himanta Biswa Sarma, who has often acknowledged in public the prime minister's influence in formulating public policies in the state.

Ever since Sarma took charge as Assam's chief minister on May 10, 2021, his government's functioning has been guided by what prime minister Modi had told him—deliver a corruption-free government which can ensure development and prosperity of every citizen of the state. As various policies of the Modi government have highlighted, the biggest obstacle to providing a clean governance is lack of transparency in execution, which creates an ecosystem for middlemen to thrive.

On July 4, while inaugurating the "Digital India Week 2022", Prime Minister Modi said that the Digital India campaign had helped the government machinery get rid of the menace called middle men who had often become obstacles in taking government services to the targeted beneficiaries. But more importantly, it helped the country save Rs 2.25 lakh crore from falling into the wrong hands in the past eight years.

Taking cue from the prime minister, Sarma embarked on a journey to rid the state of middlemen, particularly in land transaction. It was important, particularly in Assam where illegal immigration from Bangladesh has caused a huge stress on land and other resources. A large section of the indigenous people,